

https://www.somdnews.com/independent/news/local/charles-town-hall-touches-on-ice-traffic-and-data-centers/article_acd566da-442a-4d80-99e1-13c87b00f9a0.html

Charles town hall touches on ICE, traffic and data centers

Ilana Williams iwilliams@somdnews.com

Sep 17, 2025

1 of 3



David Heidelberg, a Charlotte Hall resident, talks about water issues in La Plata, data centers and traffic in Charles County during a joint town hall at the Waldorf Senior Center and Recreation Center on Sept. 16.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News



Traffic, the local economy and U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement in Charles County were a few of the items discussed during a town hall on Tuesday.

The commissioners hold quarterly joint town halls to “discuss the issues that matter to you most,” Commissioner President Reuben B. Collins II (D) said at the Waldorf Senior Center and Recreational Center. Residents had three minutes each to speak.

Traffic concerns Commute times have doubled from Southern Maryland Hospital Center to Mattawoman-Beanton Road, Jamie Larson, a Hughesville resident, said. Although resurfacing is scheduled between 9 a.m. to 3 p.m., delays occur outside that window.

Larson requested Charles County and the Maryland Department of Transportation to provide clear lane closure schedules, start and end dates and real-time updates for residents.

“Residents deserve transparent, real-time communication so we can plan our commute and not be left in the dark,” Larson said.

There needs to be more jobs in Charles County to help with traffic, like the technology corridor in Indian Head, Commissioner Gilbert “BJ” Bowling (D) said in response.

“What we’re doing in Indian Head is really a concentrated effort to get high paying and good careers,” he said.

A majority of Route 5 is in Prince George’s County, Jason Groth, director of Planning and Growth Management at Charles County, said. The Maryland Department of Transportation will be meeting with Charles County and southern Maryland next week to discuss road expansion plans and other projects.

“It’s an ongoing issue,” Groth said. “It’s a challenge we’re all facing.”

Economy and data centers mulledData centers have all kinds of issues, David Heidelberg, a Charlotte Hall resident, said. There needs to be a communication process for the residents.

“It can’t be something secret,” Heidelberg said. “These are enormously profitable companies. ... You’re going to have a very difficult time negotiating with them in a way that comes out to our advantage.”

Data centers can bring up to \$30 million a year in revenue, Bowling said. But they come with challenges like water and energy usage, impacts on the environment and noise.

“When an opportunity like data centers comes before us, we can’t just brush it off,” Bowling said. “What we have to do is a proper transparent look.”

There needs to be a better mix of residential and commercial tax revenue, Joseph Mank of Waldorf said.

“We do want to bring business into the county,” Mank said. “Economic development is important.”

The Charles County Economic Development Department and Planning & Growth Management will attend a data center meeting on Sept. 20 at Mary B. Neal Elementary School from 9:30 a.m. to 11 a.m. that is open to the public.

“The county is looking at this to get general feedback from the public from the very beginning,” Collins said.

The county needs to look at what neighboring jurisdictions are doing, Commissioner Ralph E. Patterson II (D) said.

“If you don’t have a solution to our revenue problem, then what are we doing?” Patterson said. “It can’t be housing.”

Companies that plan to build data centers in new communities should be more experienced to prevent problems in the community, Commissioner Amanda Stewart (D) said.

“Currently, I am not supporting data centers,” Stewart said. “However, I am open-minded.”

‘ICE is here’There is a provision that makes Charles County a sanctuary community, which determines the relationship between local government and ICE, Collins said. The Charles sheriff’s office approaches ICE in the county as a civil act, not a criminal act, and tends to be not as engaged.

“I can tell you ICE is real,” Collins said. “And I can tell you ICE is here ... this is impacting our community directly.”

If ICE asks for county employee records, they would need a subpoena because employee records are private, Patterson said, reading from an email sent by the Charles County Human Resources Department. The county has nothing to hide from ICE since they follow the federal law and require proof of authorization to work in the U.S., he added.

“We would not allow ICE to come in,” Patterson said.

The next joint town hall is scheduled for Dec. 9.

